

API Style Guide

Principles

APIs are contracts. Breaking changes require a major version, a migration guide, and a deprecation window of at least two quarters. Prefer additive evolution: new optional fields, new endpoints, never repurposed ones.

Conventions

Resource names are plural nouns; actions beyond CRUD use sub-resources. Timestamps are RFC 3339 UTC. Errors follow the problem-details shape with a machine-readable code, a human message, and a correlation id for Datadog tracing.

Pagination is cursor-based everywhere. Rate limiting headers mirror the API rate limiting policy: limit, remaining, and reset on every response.

Review process

Every new endpoint goes through the RFC process with an OpenAPI diff attached. The API gateway team reviews auth scopes; security reviews anything touching PII against the data classification matrix.